

THE HINDU

Puppeteer Murugan on the enduring legacy of Tamil Nadu's Bommalattam **p2**

Samatva Sambhrama embarks on a celebration of classical music **p3**



Directed by Axel
Tangerding, *The Waste
Land* will be staged in
Bengaluru **p4**



Guru Purnima prompted reflections on how open-minded gurus and questioning students are transforming the classical arts landscape

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This year's Guru Purnima felt markedly different. Coming in the wake of a major student-led protest and an unusual moment of collective introspection, it highlighted a generational shift with young people demanding to be heard and asserting their agency. That impulse is also reshaping the guru-sishya parampara in Indian classical arts, where the teacher-disciple relationship is becoming less hierarchical and more interactive.

Social media has accelerated this change, much like it recently helped build the narrative around Gen-Z nationwide.

Yet, not every guru sees technology as central to this transformation. Bharatanatyam natyacharyas, Shantha and V.P. Dhananjayan point to the enduring value of personal connections.

“Training in dance is not limited to teaching technique; it’s also about emotional mentorship. The trust that develops between teacher and student over the years is more valuable than technical accomplishment or stage success. I witnessed this during the workshop we conducted in Virginia, U.S., for 25 years. I looked forward to those sessions as much as the participants did,” says Dhananjayan.

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Suganthy Krishnamachari

Long before wooden puppetry (Bommalattam) became a recognised folk art form presented on stages in Tamil Nadu villages, it had already found a mention in Tamil literature. Among its earliest references are the *Thirukkural* couplets by Thiruvalluvar, who refers to wooden puppets (marappavai) as a powerful metaphor for life. In Kural 1,020, he says the actions of a man without modesty are like the movements of a wooden puppet operated with strings. He is as soulless as the puppet. In verse 1,058, he says that if there are no mendicants to seek charity, then the world will consist only of people who move like wooden marionettes. Such references point to the antiquity of wooden puppetry. “The art requires a knowledge of music, literature and folk arts, skill in mimicry, a sense of humour and enormous stamina,” says T.S. Murugan, of Sri Murugan Sangeetha Bommalatta sabha, who belongs to a hereditary family practising this folk art form.

“My father T.N. Sankaran, a recipient of the Sangeet Natak Akademi award, learnt Carnatic music from many gurus, one of whom was Kumbakonam Rajamanickam Pillai. Recognising his talent, Mani Iyer of Mangalagana Sabha, Kumbakonam’s most popular wooden puppetry company, asked my father to join his troupe, as a singer and also to render dialogues. Since my father was visually challenged, he did not operate the puppets. A surgery after a few years restored his vision in one eye,” he adds. Murugan further shares that, impressed by his father’s resonant singing at their wooden puppetry shows staged during the Agama Silpa Sadas, Kanchi Paramacharya honoured him with the ‘Sankaranadan’ title. Sankaran was also held in high regard by music aficionados. “E. Krishna Iyer –

The puppets’ pull

Bommalattan artiste T.S. Murugan on the challenges of crafting puppets, creating stories and sustaining long performances



lawyer and founder-secretary of the Music Academy, once arranged a puppet show at Rashtrapathi Bhavan. Mani Iyer decided to leave *appa* behind. However, Krishna Iyer insisted that the show could not go on without my father and was prepared to cancel it if he was unavailable.” When Mani Iyer passed away, Sankaran decided to have his own company, and thus was born Sri Murugan Sangeetha Bommalatta sabha. How large are the wooden puppets? “Puppets portraying children are typically about a ft tall, while those representing demons are three ft in height and weigh as much as 22 kilograms.” While traditional stories from the epics and Puranas are part of their repertoire, Murugan has also adapted the

traditional art form to address contemporary issues such as environmental conservation and AIDS awareness. A new theme means making new props, new clothes, etc. Some shows go on for hours. For instance, a recent show on Harishchandra went on for six hours. Does the audience have the patience to sit through long shows? “It all depends on how interesting the show is.” The troupe has been performing in the Ramanathapuram palace for close to 80 years. A wooden puppet show begins with a herald, giving the audience an introduction to the story. This is followed by a ‘dancer’ puppet performing a jati, thillana and a Tamil song. After this, the actual thematic performance begins. Classical compositions



weighing 15 kgs. When they reached the village where the show was to take place, they found there was no power supply, and they had to manage with petromax lights. Once when Sankaran was transporting some puppets in a rickshaw, the rickshaw puller and he stopped by to have a cup of tea, when a speeding truck hit the rickshaw, breaking 11 puppets. Recently, a suitcase full of puppets was stolen in a bus. When a complaint was lodged with the police, they told the troupe to be happy that they hadn’t lost anything valuable. “Puppets are valuable. A puppet can cost anywhere between a lakh and a lakh-and-a-half. Besides, we were on our way to a show,” rues Murugan, who further adds that wooden puppetry is not a folk art that is performed in the open like other folk art forms. “It requires a stage, a script and should be classified as theatre.” What future does the art have? “A show requires at least 15 trained persons. During my father’s time, the troupe had close to 600 people, but now we have only a few permanent members. Most of them have taken up other jobs and participate in shows only when they are free. While we continue to perform at temples across Ramanathapuram and Salem districts, many shrines that once hosted puppet shows have now stopped. Besides, remuneration doesn’t match the expenses. However, Murugan is optimistic, as his brothers, Ravi and Gopi, and his sons, Karthikeyan and Sangeeth Sriram, have all been trained in the art. Gopi, a recipient of the Yuva Purasakar, even turned down a corporate job for the sake of this art. Yet, Murugan believes individual commitment alone cannot secure the future of this traditional folk art form. “This art needs more government support if it is to be preserved for posterity,” he says.

CULTUREBRIEFS



Celebrating rain through ragas

While the monsoon may evoke images of rain-soaked streets and lush landscapes for many, it has long been a source of inspiration for musicians, who have created ragas such as Malhar, Megh, Desh, Amrithavarshini and Varunapriya, that capture its many moods, creating an enduring bond between Nature and music. Celebrating this timeless musical tradition is Barkha Ritu, India’s annual monsoon music festival. Presented by Banyan Tree, the specially curated festival has travelled across major cities for over two decades, bringing together Carnatic and Hindustani artistes to showcase the richness and diversity of India’s classical heritage. This year, the festival marks a milestone as it celebrates its silver jubilee with a multi-city tour. As part of the tour, Barkha Ritu comes to Chennai on August 1, 5.15 p.m. Presented as a fundraiser concert, the evening will open with Ramana Balachandran’s veena recital. It will conclude with a performance by Hindustani vocalist Sanjeev Abhyankar and Carnatic singer Abhishek Raghuram. The duo will present a rare collection of songs dedicated to Vitthala and Krishna. Venue: Narada Gana Sabha.

Spirit of Youth Festival

The Music Academy conducts the 36th Spirit of Youth Festival of Music and Dance from August 1 to 10 at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. A series of performances by emerging artistes will be showcased as part of the event. Each day’s performance will begin with a music concert at 6 p.m., followed by a dance recital at 7.30 p.m. The schedule: **August 1:** Shreya Ravikumar (vocal), Narthana Kanagasabai (violin), Siddhant Girish (mridangam). Deedhita Singha (Bharatanatyam). **August 2:** Pranav Kikkeri (vocal), Vishesh Upoor (violin), H. Aishwarya (mridangam) followed by Shreya Murthy (Bharatanatyam). **August 3:** Shreyas Bharadwaj (flute), Sanjay Rajesh (violin), Tejaswi Shashidhar (mridangam). Jyothsna Akilan’s Bharatanatyam performance will follow. **August 4:** Prithvi Bhaskar (vocal) with Amrutha Varshini K.S. (violin) and Aprameya H.S. (mridangam), followed by Yukthi Udupa’s

Bharatanatyam solo. **August 5:** E.R. Anirudh (vocal), Sivateja M. (violin), and Malladi Sivanand Yasasvi (mridangam). Nivedha Harish (Bharatanatyam). **August 6:** R.L. Krishna Priya (vocal), Malladi Sindhu Rageswari (violin) and Rangasubramanian K. (mridangam). This will be followed by Advith Shashidhar’s Bharatanatyam. **August 7:** U. Jaya Vigneshwar (Mandolin), V. Bargava Vignesh (violin), Saransingh A. (mridangam) and Sivasankar V. (ghatam). Swathi S’ Bharatanatyam performance will follow. **August 8:** Anirudh Sethuraman (vocal), Prahlad Saravanapriyan (violin), V.G. Rama Vaibhav (mridangam) followed by Kamakshi Kishor Hampiholi’s Bharatanatyam solo. **August 9:** Sahana Prasanna (vocal), Apurvaa S Anand (violin), Varun Rao (mridangam); and Megha Balakrishnan (Bharatanatyam). The line up concludes on August 10 with Vignesh Shankarnarayanan’s vocal concert with, B. Bhargava (violin) and Sairam Kumar (mridangam). This will be followed by Shrinaagi Venkatesh (Bharatanatyam).

A journey of faith



Govinda - A Tale of Faith, a Bharatanatyam solo production, conceived, choreographed and directed by Puja Unni of Spanda, Dubai, is on a three-city India tour following its recent premiere in Dubai. After opening in Bengaluru on July 25, the production travels to Mumbai on July 31, before coming to Chennai on August 2 at Rukmini Arangham, Kalakshetra. Featuring 12-year-old Bharatanatyam dancer Neetara Nair, ‘Govinda,’ moves beyond familiar mythological retellings to explore a personal journey of faith through five evocative segments – *Longing, The Calling, The Realisation, The Journey* and *Surrender*. Presented by ARTMOS, Govinda brings together dance, theatre-craft and stage design to explore bhakti.

Themed on Krishna



Sri Vishnu Mohan Foundation, Chennai, in association with Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Chennai Kendra, celebrates ‘Sri Krishna Utsavam’ from today to August 5 at its main auditorium, Mylapore. The event will be inaugurated this evening at 5.15 p.m. with Swami Srihariprasad’s anugraha bhashanam. N. Ravi, chairman, K.N. Ramaswamy, director, BVB, Chennai, are the chief guests. The inaugural concert will be by S. Saketharaman. The schedule: August 1, 4.30 p.m.: Dushyanth Sridhar’s discourse ‘Sri Gopala Vimshati’; 5.45 p.m.: Trichur Brothers. August 2, 11 a.m.: Suchithra Balasubramanian’s discourse. August 3, 5.45 p.m.: Vaishnavi Ramadas (vocal) and 7 p.m.: Sujata Mohapatra (Odissi). August 4, 5.45 p.m.: Gopika Varma (Mohiniyattam) and 7 p.m.: Bharatanatyam performance by Padmini Krishnamurthy and students of Sri Saraswathy Gana Nilayam Trust. August 5, 5.30 p.m.: Dhamal Ramakrishnan’s discourse. The programme is non-ticketed.

CALENDAR

Namasankirtanam

Nama Sagar, a devotional journey through nama by Vittaldas Maharaj and team will take place at the following venues this week. Details: At Hamsadhwani, Youth Hostel, Indira Nagar, Adyar, on August 2, 6.30 p.m. and at Chromepet Cultrural Academy, on August 5, 6.30 p.m.

Music concert

Narada Gana Sabha has organised the following concerts at its mini hall. Schedule: August 1, 5.30 p.m.: Varun Krishnan and 7 p.m.: Sriya R Venkat. August 2, 5.30 p.m.: Prakrithi Jayanth; 7 p.m.: Aadhya Sridharan. August 3, 6.30 p.m.: Ramakrishna C. August 4, 6.30 p.m.: Suriya Sriram. August 5: Mahanya Shree and August 6: V Saigovind (mandolin).

Nuanced notes

Bhavna Iyer’s concert had expansive raga essays and swara passages

H. Ramakrishnan

Bhavna Iyer performed at Kedaram’s eighth anniversary music festival. The highlight of the concert was her Bhairavi raga alapana. Her choice of kriti was Muthuswami Dikshitar’s masterpiece ‘Balagopala palayasumam’ in chowka kalapramana. She was able to traverse in all three octaves. The niraval and swaras were at the charanam line ‘Maanikya makuta haara valaya dhara’. Violinist M. Vijay lent able support during the alapana, niraval and swara segments. Mridangist B. Ganapathiraman’s tani, featuring several sparkling passages in tistra nadai, was engaging.



Bhavna’s singing followed the Semmangudi bani. Her initial training was under V. Subramaniam, one of Semmangudi Srinivasa Iyer’s foremost disciples. She now learns from Trivandrum G. Seethalakshmi, another distinguished disciple of the maestro. Bhavna took up raga Varali for exhaustive treatment. She chose Syama Sastri’s ‘Bangaru kamakshi’ (Misra Chapu). The alapana had delicate phrasings.

Niraval and swaras were at the anupallavi line ‘Thamadhamele rave’. Bhavna began her concert with Kothavasal Venkatarama Iyer’s popular Saveri varnam, ‘Sarasuda’. This was followed by Tyagaraja’s ‘Mummoorthulu gumigudi’ (Atana) with kalpanaswaras at the pallavi. Another Tyagaraja kriti that she sang was ‘Ni bhakti bhagya sudha’ (Rupakam), with swaras at the pallavi again. Next came raga Vasantha.

The chosen kriti was ‘Sri kamakshi katakshi’. The Tamil composition is attributed to Tiruvatur Ramaswamy Pillai, though some musicians ascribe it to Subbaraya Sastri. The chittaswara passages, swarasahitya segments and a sprinkling of swarakshara prayogas enhanced the appeal of the composition. Patnam Subramania Iyer’s ‘Iti nyayama’ in raga Malavi was rendered next. The recital concluded with the *Narayaneeyam* shloka ‘Yogeendranam’ in ragamalika (Behag, Kapi, Sindhubhairavi and Tilang); followed by Swati Tirunal’s ‘Krishna chandra radha mohana’ in Tilang and a mangalam, ‘Bhujanga sayino nama mangalam’, in Yadukula Kamboji, again by Swati Tirunal.

Having trained at Kalakshetra, they say living on campus with guru Rukmini Devi meant learning far beyond the classroom – a formative journey that influenced their lives and artistry. Yet, their teaching philosophy has evolved with the times. “The guru-sishya parampara may not be a practical model today, as the relationship has undergone a drastic transformation,” says Shantha. “A guru can no longer place himself on a pedestal. You have to keep the channels of communication open and create an atmosphere where learning becomes easier and more exciting. We adapted to that reality early on.”

While some gurus adapted to these changing dynamics, others, like Kumudini Lakhia, one of the country's most progressive dance educators and choreographers, held radical views on training at a time when disciples were expected to obey unquestioningly.

In a 2016 interview with *The Hindu*, the Kathak exponent, who passed away last year, spoke about how the rigour of the guru-sishya parampara often left her feeling claustrophobic. “After performing as a soloist for many years, I designed a distinct vocabulary for group choreography. And this was about 70 years ago, when the maharajis’ (male gurus) diktat couldn’t be defied,” she had said.

Kumudini adopted the same approach with her own students, allowing to express themselves without fear and think critically. Her foremost disciple, Aditi Mangaldas, who has carried that legacy forward through her own



Changing *dynamics*

groundbreaking Kathak choreographies, says: “Kumibehn’s aim was never to create clones or encourage mindless replication. I truly understood the significance of that when I launched my own dance company.”

Reflecting on the teacher-disciple relationship, Aditi says it must be constantly reassessed. “Every generation brings its own energy, prompting change and enabling the art form to evolve. This generation, even while learning a traditional art, insists on dialogue. They don’t want to be talked down to. As gurus, we cannot pretend to know everything. My dance company is full of Gen Z

artistes, which means you have to be prepared to answer tough questions. But that's not dissent; it means they are engaging with the art."

Unprecedented access to information has empowered students to think independently. Says Carnatic musician Rithvik Raja, “A student can access several recordings, books and lectures with a few clicks. The guru is therefore no longer the sole custodian of knowledge. But information is not the same as wisdom. The role of the guru today is perhaps even more important, not as an invincible authority, but as someone who helps cultivate discernment, aesthetic sensitivity and the

ability to listen deeply.”

Explaining that respect and questioning are not opposites, Rithvik, for whom the ideal guru-sishya relationship is neither hierarchical nor transactional, says, “The finest teachers I have known have



The recent protests are a reminder that young people deserve the freedom to express dissent. That principle should extend to every space, including artistic ones

RITHVIK RAJA

Guided shift A 2016 image of Kumudini Lakhia with students at her Ahmedabad-based school, Kadamb PHOTO: VIJAY SONEJI

encouraged questions, disagreement and independent thinking. They have taught me not what to think, but how to think. Likewise, the best students are not those who imitate perfectly, but those who engage honestly and eventually find their own voice."

Referring to the recent student protests, Rithvik says they are a reminder that young people deserve the freedom to express dissent. That principle should extend to every space, including artistic ones. But agency also comes with the responsibility to listen and to recognise that not every disagreement is oppression, just as not every exercise of authority is justified."

Today, the very foundations on which the guru-sishya system rested have changed. Institutional training, social media and global mobility have impacted both teaching and learning. "Though students can now easily access information, it does not necessarily translate into the sustained immersion that was the hallmark of the traditional learning setup. At the same time, gurus are no longer just keepers of a lineage; they are also performers, administrators, entrepreneurs and public figures. The nature of both roles has changed," says Bharatanatyam artiste Meera Sreenarayanam.

Meera believes that before asking whether the guru-sishya equation has changed, we must first ask whether the conditions that once defined a guru or a sishya still exist. “Perhaps, what many of us have today is a mentoring relationship. That does not diminish the traditional system’s value. But without mutual commitment, trust and accountability, the guru-sishya bond risks becoming merely a title rather than a lived practice,” she says.

Two-day music festival



Samatva Foundation presents 'Samatva Sambhrama 2026' on August 5 and 6, at Chowdhri Memorial Hall, Bengaluru. The event brings together well-known vocalist and instrumentalists. The festival opens with Yogesh Samsi's tabla solo (5.45 p.m.), followed by 'Strings Attached', a musical ensemble at 7.15 p.m. featuring violinist R. Kumaresh, vainika Jayanthi Kumaresh, mridangist K. Sai Giridhar and Yogesh Samsi. The events, on August 6, begins at 5.30 p.m. with 'Kashi Damaru', to be presented by Jagadeesh D. Kurthkoti and team, showcasing the vibrant rhythmic traditions of Indian classical music. The festival concludes with a special musical confluence, featuring vocalist Abhishek Raghuram, Praveen D. Rao, flautist Sruthi Sagar, thavil vidwan Mannargudi R. Vasudevan and mridangist Anantha R. Krishnan. For tickets log on to [dataformusic.com/sambhrama-2026](https://www.dataformusic.com/sambhrama-2026)



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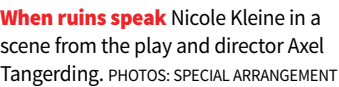
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enthusiastic we decided to do so. With this poem, Eliot broke with all traditions. It has no rhyme or fixed syllables. That's why it's called the first poem of modern literature. For my generation, it was a milestone. We too were revolting against old theatre traditions, opening the stage as a laboratory."

Meta Theatre, says Axel, is influenced by La MaMa Theatre in New York and by Jerzy Grotowski in Poland. Both were pioneers of what we now call avant-garde theatre, concentrating on the core of performance. "I felt *The Waste Land* works in a similar way," he explains, "and I compare it with Jim Jarmusch's *Only Lovers Left Alive* (2013), which zooms into situations and then leaps to the next. The impact is emotional rather than logical – not a linear continuation, but coherence that lies between the lines."

“Eliot’s text itself jumps across cultures – quoting Shakespeare, Wagner, and also the Upanishads in its closing lines with *Shantih Shantih Shantih* – weaving fragments across centuries, from antiquity to modernity,” says Axel, who observes that it is the youth who feel at home with this disrupted narrative: “They live with overwhelming, often confusing information, and must form their own view of the world. Across centuries – from two thousand years ago to today – the poem’s fractured presence resonates.”

He sees their mood caught between depression and the hope of a better future. "That tension is in Eliot's text as well – between despair after the First World War and the longing for renewal," says Axel, who is an admirer of Peter Brook. For him, Brook's radical experiments in theatre opened new ways of thinking about performance, and Eliot's poem, with its broken voices and cultural leaps, continues that tradition of disruption.



T.S. Eliot's iconic 1922 poem, *The Waste Land*, gets a theatrical adaptation

What happens when an architect-turned-director takes up T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land*? Eliot's fractured poem is transformed on stage into a living canvas. That is exactly what Axel Tangerding, founder of META Theatre Munich, does. Known for bringing his architectural sensibilities to the theatre, he treats the stage not as backdrop but as environment: a stark white square, covered with plaster, "prepared anew for each performance," then broken layer by layer to reveal what lies beneath. "It's like looking beneath the surface," he explains over a call from Germany. "In a time of fake news and fragmented realities, theatre must ask what is reliable, what comes down."

The Waste Land, presented by Jagriti Theatre in collaboration with META Theatre, will be staged

in Bengaluru till August 2 at 7.30 p.m. Featuring actor Nicole Kleine, with live music composed and performed by Ardhi Engl, the production transforms Eliot's verses into an immersive theatrical experience.

Written in 1922, Eliot's poem still haunts us. A century later, its verses continue to echo devastation, uncertainty and disillusionment. To adapt this text, Axel began by using

fragments of the poem for a libretto in musical theatre. In 2022, marking its centenary, he staged the full text as a reading with META Theatre and was astonished by the public response. “The reading was repeated, then expanded with music, later with song, until a structure slowly emerged. It was a gradual process,” he recalls. “I did not think of turning it into a play. But the audience was so